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BOONE · BLOWING ROCK · BANNER ELK · VALLE CRUCIS · WEST JEFFERSON

Welcome to the High Country

Your guide to relocating, retiring, or buying a second home in the NC mountains.

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A Place Like No Other

The North Carolina High Country sits at the top of the southern Appalachians — a region of cool summers, brilliant falls, snowy winters, and wildflower springs. It is one of the few places in the Southeast where you can trade the heat and congestion of the piedmont or coast for mountain air, a genuine downtown, world-class outdoor recreation, and a community that has maintained its character through decades of growth.

~75°F avg	3,300 ft	~2 hrs	~1.5 hrs
SUMMER HIGH	BOONE ELEVATION	TO CHARLOTTE	TO ASHEVILLE

The Communities of the High Country

Boone

The commercial and cultural hub of the High Country. Home to Appalachian State University, a vibrant King Street downtown with independent restaurants and shops, Watauga Medical Center, and easy access to all mountain corridors. Year-round population ~20,000 with a college-town energy. Median home prices have risen to **$350K–$600K+** for quality single-family homes as of 2025–2026.

Blowing Rock

A refined mountain village with a historic Main Street, upscale dining, art galleries, and the Blowing Rock attraction. Known for its luxury second-home market and well-preserved small-town character. One of the most desirable addresses in the High Country. Properties range from $500K to $2M+.

Banner Elk & Beech Mountain

Ski country. Banner Elk anchors the Sugar Mountain and Beech Mountain ski resort corridor, making it a four-season recreation destination. Strong vacation rental market. Beech Mountain (5,506 ft elevation) is the highest incorporated town east of the Rockies.

Valle Crucis & West Jefferson

Agricultural and artisan communities in the Watauga and New River valleys. Slower pace, larger properties, and lower price points. Famous for the Mast General Store (Valle Crucis) and a thriving arts scene (West Jefferson).

The Four-Season Lifestyle

Season	What to Expect
Spring	Wildflowers, trout fishing, waterfall hikes. Rhododendron blooms in June. Real estate season begins.
Summer	

	Cool 70s when the piedmont swelters. Hiking, cycling, outdoor music. Peak relocation inquiry season.
Fall	World-class color. Blue Ridge Parkway drives. Apple festivals. The reason most people fall in love with the region.
Winter	Snow and ski season. Cozy mountain towns. Lower market inventory — can be a buyer's advantage.

Boone, NC — nestled in the Blue Ridge Mountains. The only city of its size in America surrounded by this much natural beauty.

Outdoor Recreation at Your Doorstep

- **Blue Ridge Parkway:** America's most visited national park unit — miles of it run through the High Country.
- **Hiking:** Hundreds of trails in Pisgah, Jefferson, and Nantahala National Forests within an hour's drive.
- **Skiing:** Beech Mountain, Sugar Mountain, and App Ski Mountain — three resorts within 30 minutes of Boone.
- **Trout fishing:** The New River and Watauga River systems are designated blue-ribbon trout waters.
- **Mountain biking:** Pisgah trails are internationally recognized; local trails accessible from Boone.

Buying a Home or Second Home Here

The High Country real estate market has tightened considerably since 2020, with remote work migration and second-home demand pushing prices upward. Inventory remains constrained by mountain geography.

2025–2026 Market Conditions

- Median home prices in Boone: **$350K–$600K+** for quality single-family homes
- Blowing Rock and Banner Elk luxury properties: **$500K to $2M+**
- Land and older fixer properties still offer value for buyers willing to invest in improvements
- Multiple offer situations are common on desirable properties at any price point

Practical Living Information

Category	Details
Healthcare	Watauga Medical Center (Boone) — full-service hospital. Specialists in Boone or via telemedicine.
Grocery & Shopping	Walmart, Lowe's Foods, and a growing local food scene. Specialty goods via Asheville or online.
Airport Access	Tri-Cities (TRI) ~1 hr; Charlotte (CLT) ~2 hrs; Asheville (AVL) ~1.5 hrs.
Internet	Fiber and high-speed internet available in Boone proper; more variable in rural/ mountain areas.
Schools	Watauga County Schools; App State dual enrollment; several private options in the region.
Climate Note	Boone averages ~30 inches of snow per year. 4WD or AWD vehicle highly recommended.

Andrew Plyler

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Born in Boone, raised in this community, watching it grow and change for 40+ years.

There's no substitute for that kind of local knowledge when you're making a major life decision.

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